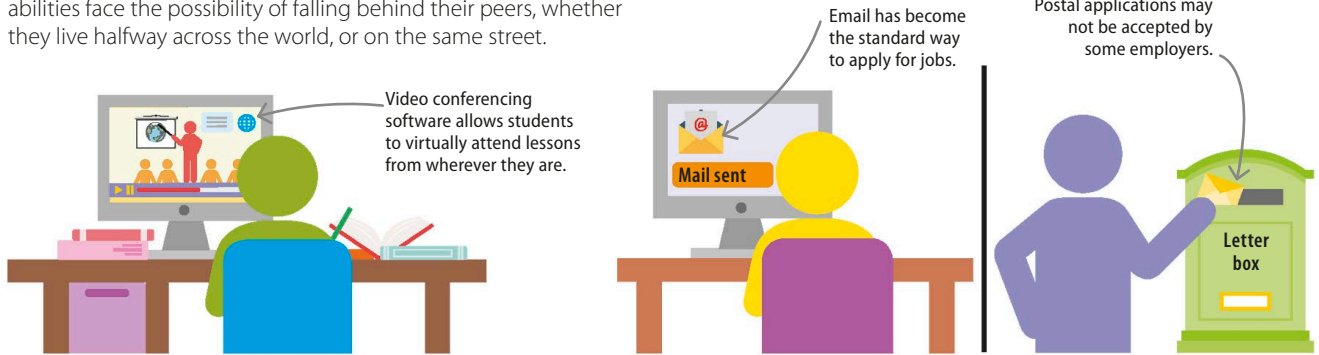


Why it matters

The internet is the greatest educational tool humans have created. The digital divide is really about the ability to access, understand, and use information. Those who lack at least one of these three abilities face the possibility of falling behind their peers, whether they live halfway across the world, or on the same street.



△ Teaching tool

Educators are increasingly turning to the internet to improve and organize their lessons. The internet has also made it easier for students in isolated communities to receive the same standard of education as everyone else.

△ In the workplace

For most jobs, being able to use the internet is a basic requirement, and an integral part of the job. Not being digitally literate is a bar to many jobs, and indeed, not being online means it's hard to even hear about job vacancies in the first place.

Who does the digital divide affect?

While generalizations can oversimplify, the fact remains that certain groups across the world tend to be on the wrong side of the digital divide. Usually a person might fall into two or more of these rough categories – for example, a woman living in a rural area.



△ Lower income people

Those without access to some of life's basics may not be able to afford digital devices, the money required to run them, and the cost of a home internet connection.



△ Women

In many parts of the world, women do not get the same educational opportunities as men. The digital divide mirrors wider pressures that women experience.



△ Elderly people

The internet as we know it really took off in the mid-1990s. Those who were not part of the explosion in internet usage may find digital devices hard to understand and use.



△ People from rural areas

People living in rural areas are more likely to have limited access to the internet. Internet providers may feel bringing fast internet to rural areas is not worth the expense.

REAL WORLD

Closing the gap



Across the world, governments, charities, and non-governmental organizations (NGOs) are trying to close the digital divide on different fronts. Many governments have established schemes to bring fast broadband internet to remote and rural areas, while providing courses in digital literacy for older people. The non-profit "One Laptop per Child" initiative has shipped millions of cost-effective laptops to kids all around the world.